JanGyan — Learn Without Limits

Category 4: Health & Emergency Awareness

Module 8 - Women, Child & Senior Citizen Health

Module Overview

Every family includes people at different life stages — a pregnant mother, a growing child, a teenager, a senior citizen — each with distinct health needs. This handbook is Module 8 of JanGyan's Health & Emergency Awareness category, and it brings together practical, government-backed guidance for the health of women, children, and senior citizens under one roof.

By the end of this handbook, you will understand safe maternal care, child health and vaccination, adolescent development, women's health awareness, menstrual hygiene, elderly care, bone health, child safety, and how nutrition needs shift across a lifetime. This module is designed as a complete, self-sufficient guide for the whole family.

Learning Objectives

After completing this module, you will be able to:

- Explain the key stages of safe maternal care in India.
- Understand the essentials of child health, growth, and vaccination.
- Recognise the health and developmental needs of adolescents.
- Identify key women's health awareness priorities, including menstrual hygiene.
- Understand the specific health needs of senior citizens.
- Explain how bone health changes across life and how to protect it.
- Apply practical child safety measures at home and outdoors.
- Adapt nutrition guidance to different family members' life stages.

Why This Topic Matters

Important

India's Maternal Mortality Ratio has fallen from 130 to 80 deaths per lakh live births between 2014–16 and 2021–23 — real progress, driven largely by awareness and access to the very government schemes covered in this handbook.

Women, children, and senior citizens often have the least visible health needs — not because they matter less, but because their care is frequently assumed rather than actively planned for. A pregnant woman who knows her entitlements, a parent who keeps vaccinations on schedule, or a family that understands an elder's changing needs can prevent enormous, often irreversible harm.

This handbook exists to make that care active and informed, rather than assumed.

Introduction

Health needs are never truly "one size fits all" — they shift significantly across a person's life, and across a

family's different members at any given time.

Definition

Life-Stage Health refers to the specific physical, nutritional, and developmental needs that change as a person moves from infancy through childhood, adolescence, adulthood, and old age.

India's public health system reflects this directly — with dedicated schemes for maternal care, child vaccination, adolescent development, and elderly care, all coordinated under the Ministry of Health & Family Welfare and the National Health Mission.

Fundamental Concepts

1. Health Across Life Stages

Life Stage	Primary Health Focus
Pregnancy	Antenatal care, safe delivery, postnatal recovery
Infancy & Childhood	Vaccination, growth monitoring, nutrition
Adolescence	Physical and emotional development, nutrition, mental health
Adulthood	Preventive screening, reproductive health, lifestyle disease prevention
Old Age	Chronic disease management, mobility, bone health, social connection

2. Nutrition for Different Age Groups

Group	Key Nutritional Priority
Pregnant & Lactating Women	Iron, folic acid, calcium, and adequate overall calories
Infants (0–6 months)	Exclusive breastfeeding, recommended by ICMR-NIN and WHO
Children	Balanced meals supporting steady growth, including protein and micronutrients
Adolescents	Higher iron and calcium needs, especially for growth spurts and menstruating girls
Senior Citizens	Adequate protein, calcium, Vitamin D, and easily digestible meals

Remember

A single family "one-size" meal plan rarely serves everyone well — small adjustments for a pregnant mother, a growing teenager, or an elderly grandparent make a real difference.

Complete Detailed Explanation

Each topic below covers what matters most, in practical, everyday terms.

3. Maternal Health

Safe motherhood depends on regular antenatal care, institutional delivery, and supported recovery afterward.

Government Support	What It Offers
Pradhan Mantri Surakshit Matritva Abhiyan (PMSMA)	Free, specialist-led antenatal checkup on the 9th of every month
Janani Suraksha Yojana (JSY)	Cash assistance encouraging institutional delivery
Janani Shishu Suraksha Karyakram (JSSK)	Free delivery, including C-section, medicines, transport, and diet
Pradhan Mantri Matru Vandana Yojana (PMMVY)	Maternity benefit cash transfer for eligible mothers

> **Tip**
> Every pregnant woman is entitled to free antenatal checkups, free institutional delivery, and postnatal care at government facilities — cost should never be a barrier to seeking care.

4. Child Health & Vaccination

Regular growth monitoring and on-schedule vaccination protect children from many serious, preventable illnesses.

- Follow the Universal Immunisation Programme schedule, which protects against 12 diseases.
- Track growth (height, weight) at regular check-ups to catch nutritional issues early.
- Complete every recommended dose — catch-up vaccination is always available if a dose is missed.

5. Adolescent Health

Adolescence (roughly ages 10–19) brings rapid physical, emotional, and social change. India's Rashtriya Kishor Swasthya Karyakram (RKSK) supports this life stage holistically — covering nutrition, safety, mental health, and general health awareness — through Adolescent Friendly Health Clinics and trained peer educators known as "Saathiya."

- Growth spurts increase the need for iron, calcium, and overall balanced nutrition.
- Emotional ups and downs are common — open family communication helps enormously.
- Peer educators and adolescent-friendly clinics offer a comfortable, confidential space for questions.

6. Women's Health Awareness

- **Anaemia:** Very common among Indian women; addressed nationally through the Anemia Mukt Bharat programme, promoting iron-folic acid supplementation and dietary awareness.
- **Regular screening:** Routine check-ups support early detection of common women's health concerns.
- **Reproductive health:** Access to accurate information and respectful healthcare is a basic right at every life stage.

7. Menstrual Hygiene

Menstruation is a normal, healthy biological process — yet limited access to hygiene products and awareness still affects many girls' education and well-being in India.

Government Initiative	What It Offers
Jan Aushadhi Suvidha Sanitary Napkin Scheme	Biodegradable sanitary pads at just ₹1 per pad, available at 15,000+ Jan Aushadhi Kendras

NHM Menstrual Hygiene Scheme	Subsidised pad packs distributed to adolescent girls via ASHA workers

Statistic

Studies suggest around 1 in 5 Indian girls have missed school due to menstruation-related challenges — showing why open awareness and access to hygiene products matter for education, not just health.

8. Elderly Care

Ageing brings changing, not necessarily declining, health needs — active and healthy ageing is achievable with the right support.

- Encourage regular, gentle physical activity and social engagement.
- Monitor chronic conditions like hypertension and diabetes consistently.
- Reduce fall risks at home with good lighting, grab rails, and clutter-free floors.
- Seek care at India's National Programme for Health Care of the Elderly (NPHCE) facilities, which offer dedicated geriatric services.

9. Bone Health

Bone density naturally changes across life — building strong bones early and protecting them later both matter.

- **Children & Adolescents:** Peak bone-building years — calcium, Vitamin D, and physical activity matter most.
- **Adults:** Maintenance through diet, weight-bearing exercise, and avoiding smoking/excess alcohol.
- **Senior Citizens:** Higher fracture risk — fall prevention, calcium/Vitamin D, and bone density checks become more important.

10. Child Safety

Most childhood injuries happen at home and are genuinely preventable with simple precautions.

- Keep medicines, cleaning products, and small objects out of children's reach.
- Supervise children near water, stairs, and roads at all times.
- Childproof furniture corners, electrical outlets, and unstable shelving.
- Teach children about safe and unsafe touch, and to always tell a trusted adult if something feels wrong.

Legal Protection

The Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act, 2012 provides a strong legal framework protecting children, including mandatory reporting requirements. CHILDLINE 1098 is India's free, 24x7 helpline for any child in distress.

Important Terminologies

Term	Simple Meaning
Antenatal Care	Medical care and checkups received during pregnancy.
Postnatal Care	Medical care and support after childbirth.
Institutional Delivery	Childbirth taking place at a hospital or health facility rather than at home.

Geriatric Care	Medical care specifically focused on the health needs of older adults.
Anaemia	A condition of low haemoglobin, very common among Indian women and girls.
Peak Bone Mass	The maximum bone density and strength typically reached in early adulthood.
ASHA Worker	Accredited Social Health Activist — a trained community health worker.

Step-by-Step Understanding

Building Healthy Family Health Practices, Step by Step

1. **Map your family's stages:** Identify each member's current life stage and its specific health priorities.
2. **Track key milestones:** Vaccination schedules, antenatal visits, and elderly check-ups, using a simple shared calendar or health card.
3. **Adjust meals thoughtfully:** Add small, targeted nutrition adjustments for pregnant members, growing children, or elderly members.
4. **Communicate openly:** Make health, including menstrual health and ageing, a normal, comfortable topic within the family.
5. **Know your entitlements:** Learn what free government services your family is eligible for, and use them.
6. **Review regularly:** Revisit your family's health plan as members move into new life stages.

Real-Life Indian Examples

Example 1

A first-time mother in rural Bihar used her free PMSMA antenatal checkup to catch a treatable complication early, avoiding a much more serious outcome later in pregnancy.

Example 2

A school in Jaipur partnered with a local Jan Aushadhi Kendra to make Suvidha sanitary pads easily available to students, noticeably reducing menstruation-related school absences.

Example 3

A joint family in Kochi installed grab rails and better lighting after their grandmother had a minor fall — a small change that prevented further incidents as she continued living independently.

Example 4

A father in Nagpur childproofed his home's electrical outlets and staircase after his toddler started walking, preventing what could have been a serious accident.

Practical Scenarios

Scenario

	What You Should Do
A pregnant family member hasn't had an antenatal checkup yet	Visit a government health facility for a free PMSMA checkup on the 9th of the month.
Your child missed a scheduled vaccine dose	Visit your nearest health centre for catch-up vaccination — it's never too late.
Your teenager seems reluctant to discuss physical or emotional changes	Keep the conversation open and non-judgemental, and mention adolescent-friendly clinics if needed.
An elderly parent seems less steady on their feet recently	Reduce fall hazards at home and consult a doctor about a geriatric check-up.
A young girl in the family is anxious about starting her period	Talk openly, normalise the topic, and ensure she knows where to access affordable sanitary products.

Government Rules & Guidelines

Programme	Focus
Pradhan Mantri Surakshit Matritva Abhiyan (PMSMA)	Free antenatal care for pregnant women
Rashtriya Kishor Swasthya Karyakram (RKSK)	Holistic adolescent health and development
Anemia Mukt Bharat	Reducing anaemia among women, girls, and children
National Programme for Health Care of the Elderly (NPHCE)	Dedicated geriatric health services
Jan Aushadhi Suvidha Scheme	Affordable menstrual hygiene products

Laws & Policies

The Maintenance and Welfare of Parents and Senior Citizens Act, 2007

This law defines the legal responsibility of children and relatives to provide maintenance for elderly parents, and enables the establishment of old age homes and medical care provisions through Section 20.

The **Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act, 2012** provides a comprehensive legal framework to protect children, including mandatory reporting obligations for adults who become aware of an offence against a child.

Important Statistics

Statistic	Insight
India's Maternal Mortality Ratio fell from 130 to 80 per lakh live births (2014–16 to 2021–23)	Reflects real, measurable progress from maternal health programmes.
RKSK reaches an estimated 253 million adolescents nationwide	Shows the scale of India's investment in adolescent health and development.
Around 1 in 5 Indian girls report missing school due to menstruation-	A reminder of how health awareness directly affects education

related issues	and opportunity.
Anaemia remains highly prevalent among Indian women, per national health surveys	A key reason Anemia Mukt Bharat targets women and girls specifically.

Suggested Visual: A "life stages" wheel showing key health priorities from infancy to old age.

Best Practices

- Attend all free antenatal checkups available through PMSMA.
- Keep every family member's vaccination and health records organised and accessible.
- Talk openly about puberty, menstruation, and ageing within the family.
- Childproof the home proactively, before an incident happens.
- Support elderly family members' independence while reducing fall and safety risks.
- Adjust nutrition thoughtfully for pregnant, growing, and elderly family members.

Common Mistakes

- Delaying antenatal checkups due to cost, despite free government services being available.
- Treating menstruation as a topic too awkward to discuss openly at home.
- Assuming an elderly family member's reduced mobility is simply "normal ageing" without medical review.
- Underestimating home hazards once a child starts crawling or walking.
- Applying the same nutrition plan to every family member regardless of life stage.

Myths vs Facts

Myth	Fact
"Antenatal checkups are only necessary if something feels wrong."	Regular checkups catch complications early, even without obvious symptoms.
"Menstruation is unhygienic or shameful."	It is a completely normal biological process — awareness and access to hygiene products are what truly matter.
"Falls and frailty are an unavoidable part of old age."	Many falls are preventable with simple home safety changes and regular check-ups.
"Teenagers' mood changes are never worth discussing."	Open, non-judgemental conversation supports healthy adolescent emotional development.
"Bone health only matters for the elderly."	Bone strength is built mainly in childhood and adolescence — early habits matter greatly.

Do's and Don'ts

Do	Don't
Attend free antenatal and postnatal checkups	Don't delay maternal care due to cost — it is free at government facilities
Keep children's vaccination schedule up to date	Don't skip catch-up vaccination if a dose is missed
Talk openly about menstruation and puberty	Don't treat these topics as shameful or forbidden
Childproof homes before accidents happen	Don't assume young children will simply "know better"
Support elderly family members' medical check-ups	Don't dismiss new mobility or memory changes as "just old age"

Safety Tips

- Keep medicines and hazardous products locked away from children.
- Improve lighting and remove trip hazards for elderly family members.
- Save CHILDLINE 1098 for any child safety concern.
- Encourage teenagers to use adolescent-friendly health services if they're more comfortable there.
- Never hesitate to seek medical help for a pregnant woman or an elderly person, even for "minor" symptoms.

Emergency

Dial **112** for unified emergency response, **108**/**102** for an ambulance, or **1098** (CHILDLINE) for a child in distress.

Practical Checklist

Family Health Checklist

☐ Pregnant family members attending regular antenatal checkups
☐ Children's vaccination schedule up to date
☐ Home childproofed for hazards (medicines, outlets, stairs)
☐ Elderly family members' homes assessed for fall risks
☐ Menstrual hygiene products accessible and discussed openly
☐ CHILDLINE (1098) and emergency numbers saved

Quick Revision Notes

Revision

- PMSMA offers free antenatal checkups on the 9th of every month.
- RKSK supports adolescents holistically — nutrition, safety, and mental health included.
- Suvidha sanitary pads are available at ₹1 through Jan Aushadhi Kendras.
- NPHCE provides dedicated geriatric care services.
- Bone health is built in youth and protected through habits across life.
- CHILDLINE 1098 is India's free, 24x7 child helpline.

Key Takeaways

Key Takeaway

1. Health needs shift meaningfully across every life stage — one-size guidance rarely fits all.
2. India's government schemes make maternal, child, adolescent, and elderly care genuinely accessible.
3. Open family conversation around menstruation, ageing, and adolescence protects everyone's well-being.
4. Most child safety incidents at home are preventable with simple precautions.
5. A family that actively plans for each member's life stage builds lasting collective health.

Glossary

Antenatal Care — Medical care received during pregnancy.

Postnatal Care — Medical care and support after childbirth.

Institutional Delivery — Childbirth at a hospital or health facility.

Geriatric Care — Medical care focused on older adults' health needs.

Anaemia — A condition of low haemoglobin levels in the blood.

Peak Bone Mass — The maximum bone density typically reached in early adulthood.

ASHA Worker — Accredited Social Health Activist, a trained community health worker.

Frequently Asked Questions

1. What is PMSMA?

A scheme offering free, specialist-led antenatal checkups to pregnant women on the 9th of every month.

2. Is institutional delivery free in India?

Yes — under JSSK, delivery including C-section is free at public health facilities, along with medicines and transport.

3. What is RKSK?

Rashtriya Kishor Swasthya Karyakram, India's national programme supporting holistic adolescent health and development.

4. Who are "Saathiya"?

Trained peer educators under RKSK who support adolescents with health information and guidance.

5. What is Anemia Mukt Bharat?

A national programme targeting anaemia reduction among women, girls, and children through supplementation and awareness.

6. How much does a Suvidha sanitary pad cost?

Just ₹1 per pad, available at Jan Aushadhi Kendras nationwide.

7. What is NPHCE?

The National Programme for Health Care of the Elderly, offering dedicated geriatric health services.

8. What does the Maintenance and Welfare of Parents and Senior Citizens Act, 2007 do?

It legally defines children's and relatives' responsibility to support elderly parents and enables old age home provisions.

9. When is bone density at its highest?

Typically in early adulthood, following bone-building during childhood and adolescence.

10. What is the most important step for preventing childhood injuries at home?

Proactive childproofing — securing hazards before an incident happens, not after.

11. What is CHILDLINE?

India's free, 24x7 helpline (1098) for any child in distress.

12. What is the POCSO Act?

The Protection of Children from Sexual Offences Act, 2012, a legal framework protecting children, including mandatory reporting requirements.

13. How has India's Maternal Mortality Ratio changed recently?

It fell from 130 to 80 deaths per lakh live births between 2014–16 and 2021–23.

14. Why do adolescents need more iron and calcium?

Due to rapid growth spurts and, for girls, the onset of menstruation.

15. Is it normal for menstruation to affect school attendance?

It shouldn't be — but limited access to hygiene products is a real barrier for many girls, which government schemes aim to close.

16. What household changes reduce fall risk for elderly family members?

Better lighting, grab rails, and clutter-free floors are simple, effective measures.

17. Should nutrition be the same for every family member?

No — needs vary meaningfully by life stage, such as pregnancy, childhood, or old age.

18. What is exclusive breastfeeding?

Feeding an infant only breast milk for the first 6 months, as recommended by ICMR-NIN and WHO.

19. What is an Adolescent Friendly Health Clinic?

A clinic under RKSK designed to offer comfortable, confidential health services specifically for adolescents.

20. Is catch-up vaccination available if a child misses a dose?

Yes — it's never too late to catch up on a missed vaccine dose.

21. What does "active and healthy ageing" mean?

Promoting ongoing physical activity, social engagement, and preventive care for older adults, rather than assuming decline is inevitable.

22. Who funds the National Programme for Health Care of the Elderly?

It is centrally sponsored, with 75% central and 25% state government funding.

23. What is a simple way to start talking about menstruation at home?

Treat it as a normal, factual health topic, and answer questions honestly and calmly.

24. Why is early childhood considered important for bone health?

Because peak bone mass is built during childhood and adolescence, shaping lifelong bone strength.

25. What is the single biggest takeaway from this handbook?

Health needs change across life stages, and India's government schemes make appropriate, affordable care available at every one of them.

Suggested Infographics, Flowcharts & Tables

Infographic: A "life stages" wheel from infancy to old age, with key health priorities.

Poster: Free maternal health entitlements under PMSMA, JSY, and JSSK.

Checklist Card: Home childproofing essentials, room by room.

Illustration: Simple home safety upgrades for elderly family members.

Card: Nutrition priorities by life stage, side by side.

Official References

- Ministry of Health & Family Welfare, Government of India — PMSMA, JSY, and JSSK maternal health guidelines.
- National Health Mission — Rashtriya Kishor Swasthya Karyakram (RKSK) implementation guidelines.
- Ministry of Women and Child Development — Anemia Mukt Bharat and Poshan Abhiyaan.
- Pradhan Mantri Bhartiya Janaushadhi Pariyojana (PMBJP) — Jan Aushadhi Suvidha Sanitary Napkin Scheme.
- Ministry of Health & Family Welfare — National Programme for Health Care of the Elderly (NPHCE).
- The Maintenance and Welfare of Parents and Senior Citizens Act, 2007, and the POCSO Act, 2012, Government of India.

Official Government Website Links

Resource	Website
National Health Mission	nhm.gov.in
Ministry of Women & Child Development	wcd.nic.in
Jan Aushadhi (PMBJP)	janaushadhi.gov.in
Ministry of Health & Family Welfare	mohfw.gov.in
CHILDLINE India	childlineindia.org

Conclusion

Every family is really a small collection of different life stages living under one roof — and each one deserves informed, active care. From a mother's antenatal checkup to a child's vaccination, an adolescent's growing independence, or a grandparent's changing needs, India's public health system offers real, accessible support at every step.

As you move ahead in the JanGyan platform, use the Practice and Quiz sections to reinforce what you've learned here, and don't hesitate to use AI Assistance whenever a doubt arises. A family that understands and plans for each member's needs builds health that lasts generations.

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